

The Shop Owner

The person who buys ProShop — a technical founder betting the business (and often their retirement) on getting the shop under control.

DECISION-MAKER

“ I can run the machines in my sleep. It's running the business that keeps me up at night.

WHO THEY ARE

The Shop Owner is usually a technical founder — a machinist or engineer who was great on the floor and started their own shop. They know the craft cold but were never trained to run a business, and the shop often is their retirement plan. They're the economic buyer for ProShop: skeptical of software promises, protective of hard-won margins, and responsible for every hire, contract, and audit.

Many run multi-generation, family-owned shops. They're pragmatic, salt-of-the-earth, and carry a high 'BS meter' — they've been pitched a lot of tools that didn't deliver. Winning them means proving real ROI, fast, in language that respects their expertise.

A DAY IN THE LIFE

Floor	Starts on the floor — still the best troubleshooter in the building, pulled into every hard setup and quality escape.
Fires	Fields the day's fires: a late job, a sick operator, a customer escalation, a machine down.
Quote	Reviews or writes quotes personally — pricing is too important to fully delegate.
Cash	Worries about cash flow, payroll, and whether the big customer will pay on time.
Grow	Tries to carve out time for the actual business — hiring, capacity, the next big contract.
Late	Does the books or the scheduling after hours, because the day never left room for it.

SNAPSHOT

Role type	Economic buyer
Background	Technical founder
Company	Often multi-gen, family
Typical size	20–75 employees
The shop is	Their retirement plan

ENVIRONMENT & TECH COMFORT

Splits their day between the shop floor and a cramped office. Comfortable with machines and CAD, wary of business software that overpromises. Time-starved and interrupt-driven — evaluates tools by whether they visibly save time or money, not by feature lists. Trust is earned slowly and lost fast.

Manufacturing expertise	Very high
Business / software comfort	Low–Medium
Skepticism of vendor claims	Very high

IN THEIR WORDS

“We existed on tribal knowledge for almost 30 years. We just existed — but we wanted to thrive. I thought it'd be hard to learn, but this old dog is learning new tricks.”

WHAT DRIVES THEM — AND WHAT GETS IN THE WAY

The lens Product & Design should hold when building for this user: what they're trying to achieve, where the current experience fails them, and what they need from the product to succeed.

● GOALS

- Get the whole business under control — out of spreadsheets and out of their head.
- Protect margin and cash flow; stop losing money to chaos and rework.
- Capture tribal knowledge before key veterans retire.
- Build something sellable — a shop that runs without them for the eventual exit.

● FRUSTRATIONS

- Disconnected systems and paper mean no one has the real picture, including them.
- They're the bottleneck — too many decisions still route through the owner.
- Every ERP they've seen felt built for big factories, not a 40-person shop.
- Hard to trust a number when the data lives in five places and a whiteboard.

● NEEDS FROM PROSHOP

- Fast, visible ROI — proof it saves real hours or dollars in weeks, not years.
- A system a high-schooler or a 30-year machinist can both actually use.
- One source of truth so they can step back without the shop falling over.
- Onboarding and support from people who've actually run a shop, not just sold software.

THE NUMBERS THEY'RE MEASURED ON

Margin

Are jobs actually profitable — and which ones aren't?

On-time %

Delivery performance that keeps demanding customers.

Cash flow

Money in vs. out — the number that keeps the doors open.

Owner load

How much still depends on them personally to run.

PROSHOP MODULES THEY LIVE IN

Company Hub / Dashboards **HOME**

Job Costing & Financial Data **HOME**

Sales & Work Orders **READS**

Quality Systems & Inspection **READS**

Shop Floor & Scheduling **READS**

WHERE THEY SIT IN THE FLOW

EVALUATES

The market

Weights ProShop against spreadsheets & rival ERPs

DECIDES



THIS PERSONA

The Shop Owner

Buys, champions & funds ProShop for the whole shop

ROLLS OUT



ENABLES

All nine user roles

Every persona in this set works in what they bought

The Shop Owner is the buyer, not a workflow role — so they sit above the job journey rather than in it. Their decision to adopt ProShop is what puts every other persona into the system. Win the owner with ROI and trust; keep them with a shop that finally runs on data instead of memory.

Buyer / decision-maker persona — distinct from the nine workflow user personas. Source: ProShop company deck (ICP & shop-owner profile) + customer testimonials. Demographic detail softened toward business-relevant traits for onboarding use.

Authored and updated 8/27/2026 by Samantha Jorgenson, Product Operations Manager

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